

Sprained Ankle: Symptoms, Treatment & Recovery Time

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Archive note: English text snapshot of the official patient-information webpage. Navigation was removed; the medical content was not translated.

What Is a Sprained Ankle?

Healthcare providers grade ankle sprains based on their severity.

An ankle sprain is an injury that happens when something stretches the ligaments in your ankles too much. Ankle sprains are very common. They're common among athletes and often after slips and falls.

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Your

ankle ligaments

are bands of tissue that hold the bones in your ankle together. They're naturally stretchy and flexible. Sprains happen when something makes your ligaments stretch too far. The extra stretch damages and tears them.

Most of the time, you can manage a mild ankle sprain at home. But visit a healthcare provider if you have symptoms like pain, swelling or trouble moving that last longer than a few days.

Types of sprained ankles

Healthcare providers grade ankle sprains based on their severity:

Grade 1 (mild):

Your ligament is stretched enough to damage it, but isn't torn much. You'll have some pain and may feel tenderness around your ankle. You can walk and shouldn't feel any instability.

Grade 2 (moderate):

Your injured ligament is torn some or most of the way through. But it's still in one piece. You'll notice more swelling, and it will hurt to move. It may be painful to walk, and you could feel unstable.

Grade 3 (severe):

Your ligament is torn completely into two pieces. This is also called a ligament rupture. You'll have severe swelling and might not be able to walk or move that ankle.

Symptoms and Causes

Symptoms of sprained ankles

Symptoms of an ankle sprain can vary depending on the grade, but usually include:

Pain, especially when you put weight on your ankle

Tenderness to touch

Swelling

Stiffness

Bruising

Sprained ankle causes

Anything that stretches your ligaments too far can sprain them. People sometimes call an ankle sprain a rolled or twisted ankle. Those names are fitting because turning your ankle too far in any one direction can damage your ligaments.

The most common causes include:

Slips

Falls

Sports injuries

Landing wrong after a jump

Ankle sprains are among the most common sports injuries, especially in sports where you change directions quickly or pivot hard on your feet. Basketball, soccer, tennis and football can all increase your risk of sprains.

Other risk factors can include:

Balance or coordination issues that make you more likely to slip or fall

High arch feet

Stiff or not very flexible ankles

Overly flexible ankles that are “looser” than usual

The less flexible your ankles are, the less resistance they have to slips, trips and sudden extra force. On the other hand, you might have a higher risk if your ankles are unusually flexible. Looser joints may be more likely to stretch too far.

Diagnosis and Tests

How doctors diagnose ankle sprains

A healthcare provider will diagnose a sprained ankle with a physical exam. You might also need some imaging tests.

Your provider will examine your ankle. Tell them when you first noticed pain, stiffness and other symptoms. If you know what caused the injury, mention that.

Your provider might use an X-ray to take pictures of your ankle and the area around it. You may also need other tests, like an ultrasound or MRI.

Management and Treatment

Sprained ankle treatment

Your provider will suggest treatments, including:

The

RICE or MEAT methods

:

These are at-home ways to manage injuries. Your provider will suggest the one that's best for you.

Over-the-counter pain relievers:

Medications like

NSAIDs

and acetaminophen relieve pain and reduce inflammation. Don't take them for more than 10 days in a row without talking to your provider.

Protecting your ankle:

Wearing a brace, wrap or splint can relieve swelling and keep pressure off your injured ankle. Your provider may also suggest using crutches if you have a higher-grade sprain or if walking is hard or painful.

Physical therapy:

Your provider might suggest exercises and stretches you can do at home to help your ankle regain its strength and flexibility. You might want to meet with a physical therapist, too.

Surgery:

It's rare to need surgery for a sprained ankle. But you might if you have a grade 3 sprain (a ligament rupture). Your provider may suggest surgery if you sprain the same ankle several times. They'll tell you when you should consider it and what to expect.

Recovery time

How long it takes to recover from a sprained ankle depends on the type you have. Mild ankle sprains heal faster than more severe ones.

It usually takes a week or two for mild sprains to heal. But it can take up to several months to recover if you have a complete ligament tear. Especially if you need surgery.

When should I see my healthcare provider?

You don't need to see a healthcare provider for very mild sprains. But don't ignore symptoms.

Visit a provider if swelling and pain haven't gotten better (or get worse) a day or two after you tweak your ankle. See someone right away if you can't walk or put any weight on your ankle.

Outlook / Prognosis

What can I expect if I have an ankle sprain?

Even higher-grade ankle sprains get better with treatment.

Talk to your healthcare provider before resuming sports or physical activities. They'll tell you when it's safe to start moving again. You can make a mild sprain worse if you put too much pressure on your injured ankle before it's healed.

Your provider will tell you when you should start moving your ankle again. Gentle movements and mobility exercises can help prevent chronic stiffness.

Additional Common Questions

What is the difference between a sprained ankle and an ankle fracture?

A sprained ankle is torn ligaments in your ankle. An

ankle fracture

is a broken bone in your ankle.

Severe ankle sprains and fractures have similar symptoms. And they can share causes.

Visit a healthcare provider if you think you have a broken bone, or if you have pain and swelling that last for more than a few days.